

General Knowledge

Modern History

STUDY NOTES

Freedom Movement - Moderate Phase (1885 - 1905)



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Introduction

The period from **1885 to 1905** is often referred to as the Moderate Phase in Indian history. This was the early phase of the Indian National Congress (INC), where the leaders believed that they could bring about political and administrative reforms by working within the framework of British rule. Their approach was to seek reforms through peaceful means like discussions, petitions, and resolutions.

Freedom Movement:

Category	Details
Time-Period	1885 - 1905
Key Leaders	Dadabhai Naoroji, Gopal Krishna Gokhale, Surendranath Banerjee, Pherozeshah Mehta
Aims	Constitutional reforms, self-governance, demand for representation in legislative councils
Methods	Petitions, meetings, speeches, resolutions, appeals to the British sense of justice
Beliefs	Faith in British fairness and gradual reforms through constitutional methods
Major Events	- Formation of Indian National Congress (INC) in 1885 - Dadabhai Naoroji's theory of the "Drain of Wealth" - Representation in councils
Major Demands	- Indianization of civil services - Reduction in military expenditure - Economic reforms (tax reductions, free trade)

Criticism	Lack of direct action, slow progress, reliance on British goodwill
Achievements	- Raised national consciousness - Laid foundation for future struggle - Economic critiques like “Poverty and Un-British Rule in India”
End of Phase	1905 - Rise of Extremists, Partition of Bengal

Key Characteristics

- They Believed in British justice and **constitutional methods**.
- The primary focus was on **reforms**, not full independence.
- They advocated for incremental changes, using moderate methods like petitioning the British government and passing resolutions in the INC meetings.
- Most leaders were **well-educated elites** who respected the British system and believed in working within it.

Major Leaders:



Dadabhai Naoroji:

- He is known for his work on the **Drain of Wealth Theory**, which argued that Britain was draining India's wealth.
- He is also known as the "**Grand Old Man of India**" and was the first Indian to become a **British MP**.

Gopal Krishna Gokhale

- Gokhale was a social reformer, educator, and moderate leader who believed in gradual reforms for the betterment of India under British rule.
- He founded the **Servants of India Society** in **1905**, aiming to promote selfless service to the country.
- Gokhale advocated for political and social reforms, focusing on education, poverty alleviation, and the welfare of the people.
- A member of the Indian National Congress, he emphasized cooperation with the British for reforms, but his moderate stance made him differ from leaders like Bal Gangadhar Tilak.
- Gokhale was an important mentor to Mahatma Gandhi, who was greatly influenced by his moderate views and methods of peaceful reform.

Surendranath Banerjee

- Banerjee was a key figure in the early stages of the Indian National Congress and founded the **Indian National Association** in 1876, which aimed at promoting political reforms and representation for Indians.
- He was known for his moderate approach to politics and focused on the rights of Indians to participate in governance.
- A champion of education and social reform, Banerjee advocated for the promotion of Indian languages and culture.
- Banerjee was also a notable journalist and worked to spread nationalist ideas through his publications, such as **The Bengalee**.
- He played an active role in the Bengal Renaissance and supported movements for the social upliftment of women and the abolition of harmful practices like child marriage.

Major Events

- **Formation of the Indian National Congress (1885):** The INC was established to promote Indian interests within the British Empire.
- **Partition of Bengal (1905):** Lord Curzon's decision to divide Bengal based on religion led to widespread opposition, marking a critical point in Indian nationalism. This event also caused a shift towards the more radical Extremist phase in Indian politics.

Moderates' Key Demands

The Moderates had a list of demands they consistently raised with the British:

- **Expansion of legislative councils** to give Indians a greater voice.
- **Reduction** in military expenditure.
- Indianization of administrative services to **allow more Indians in high positions**.
- **Separation of the executive and judiciary** to ensure fairness in trials.
- A call for **self-government** but still within the framework of the British Empire.

Methods Used by Moderates

- **Petitions and Appeals:** They often sent petitions to the British government in hopes of persuading them to grant reforms.
- **Delegations:** Delegations were sent to Britain to discuss Indian issues and push for more representation in the British government.
- **Press and Publicity:** The Moderates made extensive use of the media to spread their message and gain support from both the Indian public and British authorities.

Important Reforms and Laws

- **Indian Councils Act (1892):** This Act provided limited representation to Indians in the legislative councils but fell far short of the Moderates' expectations.
- **Economic Criticism:** Leaders like Naoroji emphasized the **Drain of Wealth**, showing how British economic policies were harming India.

Detailed View of Freedom Movement - Moderate Phase (1885 - 1905)

- This phase is referred to as the Moderate Phase or the Period of **Tea-Party Politics or Political Mendicancy**.
- The term "**Tea Party**" was inspired by the **Boston Tea Party** of **1773**, where American colonists protested British taxation.
- The moderate leaders avoided extreme measures and believed in achieving reforms through constitutional methods and proper demands.

Indian Council Act of 1892:

The Indian Council Act of 1892 was a landmark development influenced by the efforts of the Moderates. Key features included:

- The act expanded the size of legislative councils and allowed for the election of some Indian members, though the overall representation remained limited.

- **Discussion of Budget and Laws:** Indian members were permitted to discuss budgets and proposed laws, giving them a platform to voice their concerns and influence policy decisions.
- **Impact on Nationalism:** While the act did not grant full self-governance, it represented a step towards greater political participation for Indians and laid the groundwork for future demands for more substantial reforms.

Formation of Indian National Congress (INC)

- The **Indian National Congress (INC)** was founded in **December 1885** in **Bombay**.
- Credit for founding INC goes to **A.O. Hume**, a retired British Civil Servant, who organized the session with prominent Indian leaders.
- **Hume's role:** He intended to use the INC as a safety valve to release the growing discontent among educated Indians, while Congress leaders saw him as a lightning conductor.
- The Indian National Congress was founded in **December 1885** in **Bombay** (now **Mumbai**).
- The first session of the INC took place at the Gokuldas Tejpal Sanskrit College, and it was presided over by **W.C. Bonnerjee**. There were **72** delegates from diverse backgrounds, which made the Congress a truly inclusive platform.
- The formation of the INC marked the beginning of a new political era in India. It provided a space for Indians to come together and civilly discuss their grievances, laying the foundation for future movements toward self-rule.
- Key figures like **Dadabhai Naoroji** and **Surendranath Banerjee** were also present in that first session, contributing to the Congress's initial direction.
- Overall, the **INC** aimed to bring together Indians from various regions, castes, and professions, making it the first all-India political organization. This inclusiveness was vital in fostering a sense of **national identity** among Indians.



THE FIRST INDIAN NATIONAL CONGRESS, 1885.

Composition of INC During the Moderate Phase

- Key Presidents: **W.C. Bonnerjee, Dadabhai Naoroji, Badruddin Tyabji, Pherozeshah Mehta, Gopal Krishna Gokhale, Surendranath Banerjee.**
- Badruddin Tyabji became the first Muslim President of the INC.
- Early Congress had less female participation but later increased. In **1890, Kadambini Ganguly**, the **first woman graduate**, addressed the Congress.
- The first session in 1885 had 72 delegates, and by 1886 in Calcutta, it grew to **434** delegates.

Dadabhai Naoroji's Theory of the "Drain of Wealth"

- Naoroji's theory, articulated in his book "Poverty and Un-British Rule in India" (1901), argued that British colonial policies led to a **systematic economic exploitation** of India.
- He asserted that wealth produced in India was being transferred to Britain without any corresponding benefit to the Indian **economy**, creating widespread poverty and deprivation.
- This theory was instrumental in raising awareness about economic injustices among Indians and became a cornerstone of Indian nationalist thought, linking political freedom with economic independence.

Representation in Councils

- The **INC** advocated for the inclusion of Indians in **legislative councils** to give them a voice in governance. Early demands included:
- Increased Indian representation in the Legislative Councils.
- The right to discuss and vote on matters affecting Indian interests.
- **Minto-Morley Reforms (1909):** Although the initial demands were met with resistance, the reforms allowed for limited representation of Indians in councils, marking a step towards political participation.
- **Provisions:** The reforms introduced separate electorates for Muslims and increased the number of Indian representatives in the councils.
- **Significance:** The push for representation laid the groundwork for future political mobilization and the demand for self-governance.

Partition of Bengal

The Partition of Bengal in 1905 stands as a pivotal moment in Indian history, shaping the political and social landscape of the time.

- **Background**

- At the time, Bengal was not only the most populous province of British India but also a thriving center of political and cultural awakening. However, the British government claimed that Bengal was too vast and unwieldy to govern effectively.
- They cited administrative efficiency as the reason for the impending partition, setting the stage for significant unrest.

- **The Partition**

- On **July 19, 1905**, the British officially announced the partition, dividing Bengal into two parts:
 - **East Bengal and Assam**, were predominantly **Muslim** areas.
 - **West Bengal**, which had a majority **Hindu** population.
 - This division was strategic; the British hoped to create a wedge between **Hindus** and **Muslims**, believing that fostering communal discord would weaken the growing nationalist movement.

- **Reactions to the Partition**

- The announcement of the partition ignited immediate backlash across India.
- Nationalist leaders from the **Indian National Congress** and other organizations voiced strong opposition, sparking widespread protests.
- This resistance gave rise to the Swadeshi Movement, which encouraged Indians to boycott British goods and support indigenous industries.
- Moreover, the partition catalyzed cultural revival, inspiring a sense of nationalism that transcended religious boundaries. Calls for unity among Indians grew louder as people rallied against what they saw as a divisive British strategy.

- **Consequences**

- The agitation against the partition led to a surge in political mobilization among the Indian populace.
- Nationalistic sentiments reached new heights, as many Indians became increasingly aware of their political rights and the need to resist colonial rule.
- This period also saw the formation of various nationalist organizations, such as the Anushilan Samiti, which actively worked to oppose British authority.

- Ultimately, the relentless pressure from Indian activists forced the British government to reverse the partition on December 12, 1911, reuniting Bengal.

- **Long-term Impact**

- While the partition was rescinded, it left an indelible mark on Indian society.
- It sowed seeds of communal tension that would have far-reaching implications, particularly during the Indian independence movement and the subsequent partition of India in 1947.
- In a broader sense, the events surrounding the partition highlighted the growing importance of mass mobilization in the Indian freedom struggle.
- It underscored how regional identities and collective action could challenge colonial rule, marking a significant turning point in the fight for independence.

Swadeshi Movement:

The Swadeshi Movement was a powerful grassroots response to the Partition of Bengal and had several important aspects:

- **Boycott of Foreign Goods:** The movement called for the boycott of British products, promoting Indian-made goods as a way to challenge colonial economic dominance. This led to a surge in local industries and handicrafts.
- **Cultural Revival:** The movement inspired a renewed interest in Indian culture, heritage, and nationalism. Events like the Swadeshi Mela (fairs) celebrated indigenous crafts and products.
- **Unity Across Communities:** The Swadeshi Movement transcended regional and communal lines, uniting people from diverse backgrounds in a common cause, fostering a sense of solidarity and national pride.

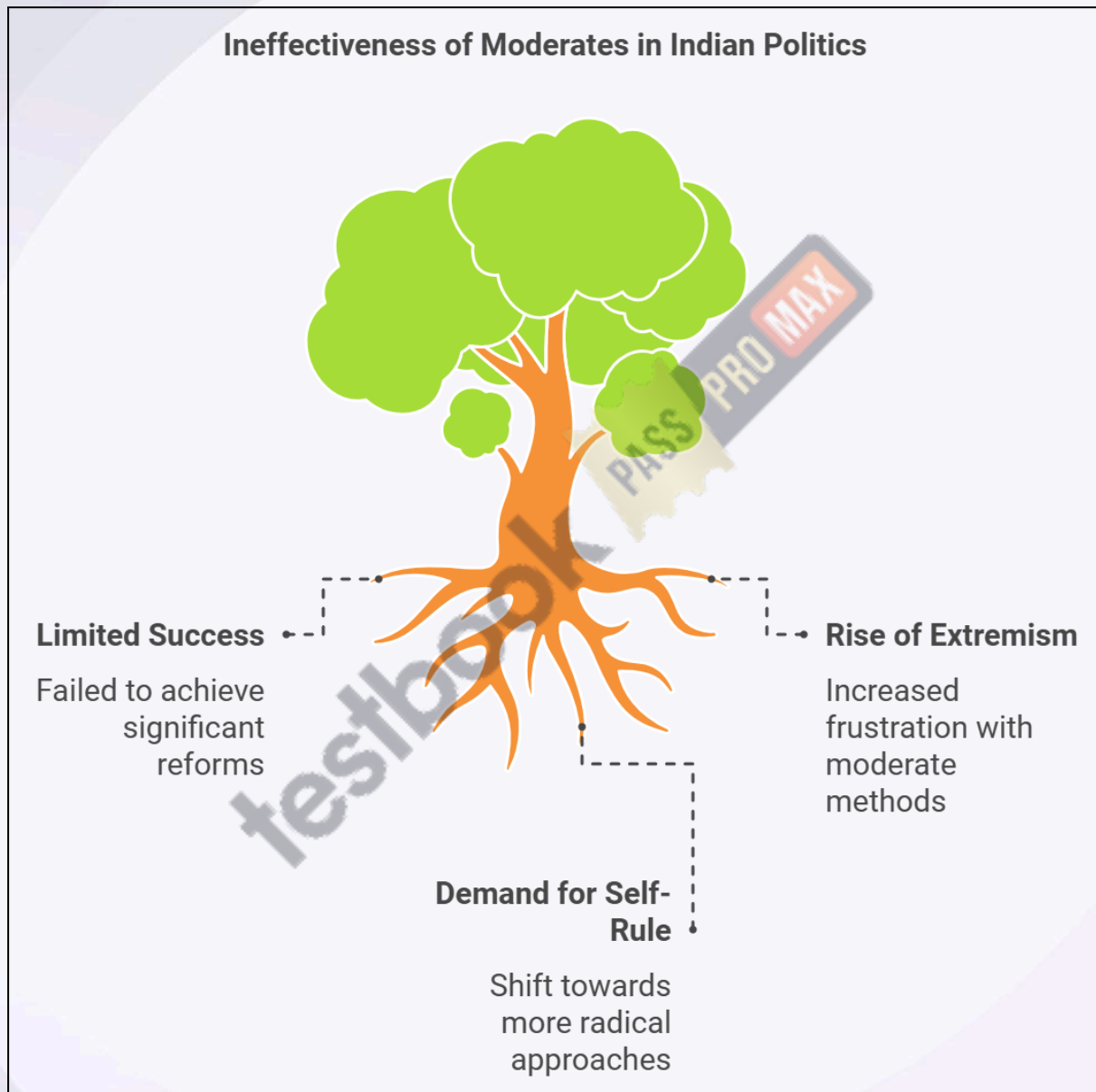
Moderates vs. Extremists

- Early Congress leaders were liberal and moderate, preferring democratic and constitutional methods. Hence, they were termed Moderates.
- The Extremists, or neo-nationalists, advocated for radical measures to oppose British rule.
- In 1907, the Congress split into two factions due to ideological differences—**Moderates** and **Extremists**.

- **Public Support:** The Moderates mainly drew support from the educated middle class, while the Extremists had a broader base, attracting both the middle class and rural masses, especially from Maharashtra and Bengal.
- **Influence on Future Movements:** The Moderates influenced future leaders like Mahatma Gandhi, who initially adopted their constitutional methods, whereas the Extremists inspired revolutionary activities and militant nationalism, contributing to the rise of groups like the Ghadar Party and Anushilan Samiti.

Category	Moderates	Extremists
Time Period	Late 19th century (roughly 1885–1905).	Early 20th century (roughly 1905–1919).
Key Leaders	Gopal Krishna Gokhale, Dadabhai Naoroji, Pherozeshah Mehta, Surendranath Banerjee, R.C. Dutt, and others.	Bal Gangadhar Tilak, Bipin Chandra Pal, Lala Lajpat Rai, Aurobindo Ghosh, and others.
Beliefs	Believed in gradual reforms, cooperation with the British, and constitutional methods.	Advocated for radical and immediate action, including confrontation with the British.
Approach	Constitutional means, petitions, and representation.	Militant actions, self-reliance, and sometimes violence to achieve independence.
Forms of Protest	Petitions, resolutions, public speeches, and writing in newspapers.	Boycotts, strikes, mass mobilization, and sometimes violent protests (e.g., the Swadeshi Movement).
View on the British	Believed in persuading the British government through petitions and negotiations.	Critical of British rule and demanded complete independence from the British Empire.
Ideological Stance	Liberal and moderate; believed in gradual reforms and the development of constitutional means.	Radical and assertive; aimed at achieving self-rule by any means necessary.
Support Base	Educated Indians, upper-middle class, bureaucrats, and elites.	Masses, students, and the growing nationalist sentiment in India.
Famous Movements	Indian National Congress (INC) under moderate leadership, founding of the Indian National Association.	Swadeshi Movement, Partition of Bengal (1905), and the rise of the Extremist wing of INC.
Response to British Rule	Sought moderate reforms like the Indian Councils Act (1892), and believed in dialogue with the British.	Strongly opposed British rule, calling for complete independence and rejecting constitutional reforms.

Legacy	Played a key role in laying the foundation for the Indian independence movement through constitutional methods.	Shifted the movement towards mass action and helped ignite the more radical phase of the freedom struggle.
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Beliefs and Ideals of Moderates:

- Moderates believed in peaceful, constitutional agitation within the law.
- They thought that British rulers were just unaware of Indian conditions and that India could achieve self-governance gradually.

- They believed in creating public opinion through meetings, petitions, and resolutions.

Approach of Moderates

- Their approach involved a two-pronged strategy:
- Raise awareness and arouse national consciousness.
- Persuade the British Government to introduce reforms through prayers, petitions, and protests.
- They conducted their work through meetings, speeches, resolutions, and petitions.

Demands of Moderates

- Modest demands, focusing on representation in government bodies rather than immediate independence.
- Indian representation in the Viceroy's Executive Council, Governor's Executive Council, and Civil Services.
- End of economic exploitation (Drain of Wealth theory).
- Reduction of land revenue and military expenditure.
- Civil rights like freedom of speech, press, and association.

Achievements and Contributions

- Although they failed to achieve major success, their sustained efforts led to the **Indian Council Act of 1892**.
- The Economic critique of British imperialism by leaders like **Dadabhai Naoroji** and **R.C. Dutt** helped expose the **Drain of Wealth**.
- Moderates spread awareness of **civil rights**, which later became integral to the freedom struggle.

Conclusion

- Moderates succeeded in establishing the political truth that **India** should be **ruled** in the **interests of Indians**.
- They laid the **foundation** for the **mass-based national movement** that followed, even though they did not achieve much success during their time.
- The **rise of extremism** after **1905** showed the growing frustration with the moderates' methods, leading to demands for self-rule.